ENGLISH B2 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Past ability and achievement

Choose could for general ability and managed to, succeeded in or was able to for a specific successful event. The lesson connects form, meaning, register and real editorial decisions rather than treating the pattern as an isolated rule.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Use past ability and achievement to distinguish general capacity from a single achieved or failed outcome while preserving the intended meaning and register.

Choose could for general ability and managed to, succeeded in or was able to for a specific successful event.

MODEL

Despite the outage, the team managed to recover the files.

could + base | managed to / was able to + base | succeeded in + -ing

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Recognise the main past ability and achievement patterns in authentic contexts.

OUTCOME 2

02

Choose a form that accurately expresses distinguish general capacity from a single achieved or failed outcome.

OUTCOME 3

03

Avoid errors that change time, agency, emphasis or speaker commitment.

OUTCOME 4

04

Use the structure appropriately in biography, performance review, incident reports and storytelling.

Build meaning before form

Choose could for general ability and managed to, succeeded in or was able to for a specific successful event.

What past ability and achievement communicates

Choose could for general ability and managed to, succeeded in or was able to for a specific successful event.

The central purpose is to distinguish general capacity from a single achieved or failed outcome. A successful choice therefore preserves the proposition while making the intended relationship, viewpoint or degree of commitment visible to the reader.

At sixteen, Lena could speak three languages.	a repeated or continuing ability in the past
Despite the outage, the team managed to recover the files.	success in one difficult past situation
The technician was unable to reproduce the fault.	failure in a specific past attempt

How the pattern is built

Use this working formula: could + base | managed to / was able to + base | succeeded in + -ing. The formula is a decision path: it identifies the trigger, the clause architecture and the element that carries tense or modality.

The model “Despite the outage, the team managed to recover the files.” shows the complete pattern in context. Rebuild the sentence from meaning to form instead of translating each word independently.

Choice	Structure	Example
General ability	could + base verb	At sixteen, Lena could speak three languages.
Specific achievement	managed to / was able to + base	Despite the outage, the team managed to recover the files.
Failed attempt	could not / was unable to + base	The technician was unable to reproduce the fault.

Choose by meaning, not by surface similarity

Neighbouring structures may contain similar words but perform different jobs. Compare the three reference patterns and name the intended effect before completing the sentence.

A reliable answer explains both why the chosen form works and why a plausible alternative would change the meaning, time relation, information focus or level of certainty.

Meaning	Best route
a repeated or continuing ability in the past	General ability
success in one difficult past situation	Specific achievement
failure in a specific past attempt	Failed attempt

Register, discourse and editorial control

This grammar is especially useful in biography, performance review, incident reports and storytelling. Its value comes from helping the reader process a relationship efficiently, not from making the sentence sound artificially complex.

After editing, check recoverability, natural word order and consistency with the surrounding paragraph. If the marked structure creates ambiguity, return to a fuller or more neutral clause.

Reason through the pattern

The visual map moves from communicative purpose to structural trigger, then to the final clause. It keeps meaning and form visible at the same time so the learner can justify every choice.

01	02	03	04	05	06
could	base	managed to / was able to	base	succeeded in	-ing

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: distinguish general capacity from a single achieved or failed outcome.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Check time reference, clause relationships, agency and speaker commitment.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Read the complete sentence in context and confirm that its register suits biography, performance review, incident reports and storytelling.

STEP 5

Decision 5

Compare the result with a neutral alternative and keep the marked form only when it adds useful meaning.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Pattern	Form	Model
General ability	could + base verb	At sixteen, Lena could speak three languages.
Specific achievement	managed to / was able to + base	Despite the outage, the team managed to recover the files.
Failed attempt	could not / was unable to + base	The technician was unable to reproduce the fault.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

At sixteen, Lena could speak three languages.	a repeated or continuing ability in the past
Despite the outage, the team managed to recover the files.	success in one difficult past situation
The technician was unable to reproduce the fault.	failure in a specific past attempt

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not use managed to for a broad continuing ability without a specific achievement.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Avoid could for a single affirmative achievement when success is central.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not use did not manage without to before the verb.

Recognition in context

Choose the sentence whose grammar matches the stated communicative purpose.

A1 · MEANING DECISION 1

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a repeated or continuing ability in the past?

OPTIONS At sixteen, Lena could speak three languages. · Despite the outage, the team managed to recover the files. · The technician was unable to reproduce the fault.

A2 · MEANING DECISION 2

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: success in one difficult past situation?

OPTIONS Despite the outage, the team managed to recover the files. · The technician was unable to reproduce the fault. · At sixteen, Lena could speak three languages.

A3 · MEANING DECISION 3

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: failure in a specific past attempt?

OPTIONS The technician was unable to reproduce the fault. · At sixteen, Lena could speak three languages. · Despite the outage, the team managed to recover the files.

A4 · INTERPRETATION 4

What does “At sixteen, Lena could speak three languages.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a repeated or continuing ability in the past · success in one difficult past situation · failure in a specific past attempt

A5 · INTERPRETATION 5

What does “Despite the outage, the team managed to recover the files.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS success in one difficult past situation · failure in a specific past attempt · a repeated or continuing ability in the past

A6 · INTERPRETATION 6

What does “The technician was unable to reproduce the fault.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS failure in a specific past attempt · a repeated or continuing ability in the past · success in one difficult past situation

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Form and function

Identify both the structural family and the meaning carried by each model.

B1 · FORM AND FUNCTION 1

"At sixteen, Lena could speak three languages." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: General ability / Specific achievement / Failed attempt · Gap 2: a repeated or continuing ability in the past / success in one difficult past situation / failure in a specific past attempt

B2 · FORM AND FUNCTION 2

"Despite the outage, the team managed to recover the files." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Specific achievement / Failed attempt / General ability · Gap 2: success in one difficult past situation / failure in a specific past attempt / a repeated or continuing ability in the past

B3 · FORM AND FUNCTION 3

"The technician was unable to reproduce the fault." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Failed attempt / General ability / Specific achievement · Gap 2: failure in a specific past attempt / a repeated or continuing ability in the past / success in one difficult past situation

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided discourse choices

Maintain accurate form and meaning across a connected sequence of decisions.

C1 · EDITORIAL PLANNING

Choose the model that expresses a repeated or continuing ability in the past: _____. Choose the model that expresses success in one difficult past situation: _____. Choose the model that expresses failure in a specific past attempt: _____. Choose the model built with could + base verb: _____. Choose the model built with managed to / was able to + base: _____. Choose the model built with could not / was unable to + base: _____.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

At sixteen, Lena could speak three languages. · Despite the outage, the team managed to recover the files. · The technician was unable to reproduce the fault.

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open reconstruction

Recover the missing structural trigger without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT RECONSTRUCTION

At sixteen, Lena _____ three languages. Despite the outage, the team _____ the files. The technician _____ the fault. State the full structural pattern for General ability: _____. State the full structural pattern for Specific achievement: _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled transformation

Rewrite the neutral source so that it performs the requested advanced function.

E1 · TRANSFORMATION 1

Rewrite “Speaking three languages was a general ability.” using the General ability pattern to express a repeated or continuing ability in the past.

_____
_____

E2 · TRANSFORMATION 2

Rewrite “The team succeeded in that particular recovery.” using the Specific achievement pattern to express success in one difficult past situation.

_____
_____

E3 · TRANSFORMATION 3

Rewrite “The attempt to reproduce the fault did not succeed.” using the Failed attempt pattern to express failure in a specific past attempt.

_____
_____

E4 · TRANSFORMATION 4

Rewrite “Speaking three languages was a general ability.” using the General ability pattern to express a repeated or continuing ability in the past.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative production

Use the grammar independently in realistic academic, professional and conversational contexts.

F1 · PRODUCTION TASK 1

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use General ability to express a repeated or continuing ability in the past, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · PRODUCTION TASK 2

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Specific achievement to express success in one difficult past situation, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · PRODUCTION TASK 3

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Failed attempt to express failure in a specific past attempt, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

07 · RETRIEVAL

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: communicative purpose.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: structural trigger.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: meaning contrast.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register choice.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

At sixteen, Lena could speak three languages.

General ability is the best match because a repeated or continuing ability in the past.

A2

Despite the outage, the team managed to recover the files.

Specific achievement is the best match because success in one difficult past situation.

A3

The technician was unable to reproduce the fault.

Failed attempt is the best match because failure in a specific past attempt.

A4

a repeated or continuing ability in the past

The General ability pattern communicates a repeated or continuing ability in the past.

A5

success in one difficult past situation

The Specific achievement pattern communicates success in one difficult past situation.

A6

failure in a specific past attempt

The Failed attempt pattern communicates failure in a specific past attempt.

Form and function

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

General ability / a repeated or continuing ability in the past

The structure belongs to the General ability pattern. Its communicative purpose is a repeated or continuing ability in the past.

B2

Specific achievement / success in one difficult past situation

The structure belongs to the Specific achievement pattern. Its communicative purpose is success in one difficult past situation.

B3

Failed attempt / failure in a specific past attempt

The structure belongs to the Failed attempt pattern. Its communicative purpose is failure in a specific past attempt.

Guided discourse choices

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

At sixteen, Lena could speak three languages.

General ability: could + base verb.

C2

Despite the outage, the team managed to recover the files.

Specific achievement: managed to / was able to + base.

C3

The technician was unable to reproduce the fault.

Failed attempt: could not / was unable to + base.

C4

At sixteen, Lena could speak three languages.

General ability: could + base verb.

C5

Despite the outage, the team managed to recover the files.

Specific achievement: managed to / was able to + base.

C6

The technician was unable to reproduce the fault.

Failed attempt: could not / was unable to + base.

Open reconstruction

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

could speak

General ability requires “could speak” in this model. could + base verb.

D2

managed to recover

Specific achievement requires “managed to recover” in this model. managed to / was able to + base.

D3

was unable to reproduce

Failed attempt requires “was unable to reproduce” in this model. could not / was unable to + base.

D4

could + base verb

General ability is built as could + base verb.

D5

managed to / was able to + base

Specific achievement is built as managed to / was able to + base.

Controlled transformation

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

At sixteen, Lena could speak three languages.

could + base verb. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended general ability effect.

E2

Despite the outage, the team managed to recover the files.

managed to / was able to + base. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended specific achievement effect.

E3

The technician was unable to reproduce the fault.

could not / was unable to + base. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended failed attempt effect.

E4

At sixteen, Lena could speak three languages.

could + base verb. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended general ability effect.

Communicative production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

At sixteen, Lena could speak three languages. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses could + base verb accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F2

Despite the outage, the team managed to recover the files. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses managed to / was able to + base accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F3

The technician was unable to reproduce the fault. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses could not / was unable to + base accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____